

Idolatry Root Sin

doc-idolatry-root-sin

Hamartiology · Root of Sin · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

Idolatry (exchanging the glory of the Creator for created things) is the root of all sin; every transgression is a derivative form of misplaced worship.

In plain language

This proposition makes a ranking claim, that idolatry is the one root of all sin and every other sin is just misdirected worship. The text strongly supports a softer version of this. In Romans 1 verses 21 to 25 Paul says people knew God but did not glorify him, then exchanged his glory (doxa) for images (eikon) and served created things instead of the Creator, and the word therefore introduces the long list of other sins, which makes those sins look downstream of the worship failure. Colossians 3 verse 5 and Ephesians 5 verse 5 even say that greed (pleonexia) is idolatry (eidololatria), using language of identity, not comparison. The first of the Ten Commandments also comes first, no other gods before my face. So idolatry is clearly a deep and across-the-whole-Bible category. But the stronger ranking claim runs into a problem in the words themselves. The one place the Bible plainly says a sin is a root of all evils is 1 Timothy 6 verse 10, and there the sin named is the love of money (philargyria, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), not idolatry, and the word root (riza) has no the in front of it, so it means a root, not the only root. Hebrews 12 verse 15 speaks of a root of bitterness (pikria), Hebrews 3 verse 12 of an evil heart of unbelief (apistia) that departs from God, and Proverbs 16 verse 18 puts pride before a fall. James 1 verses 14 and 15 say desire (epithymia) conceives and gives birth to sin, and 1 John, the same letter that ends guard yourselves from idols (eidolon), earlier sorts worldly sin into desire of the flesh, desire of the eyes, and pride of life. So the canon hands us several roots and never lines them up to crown one as the single fundamental sin. You can knit them together, since greed is called idolatry and idolatry can be called the deepest exchange, but that knitting is a reading the bare words allow rather than force. That is why this lands as disputed, the vocabulary supports idolatry as a central root but does not by itself rank it as the only root.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0312	אֲחֵר	acher	another	166
H0410	אֵל	el	God	
H0430	אֱלֹהִים	elohim	God	
H1544	גִּלּוּל	gillul	idol	48
H1875	דָּרַשׁ	darash	to seek	
H3068	יְהוָה	yehovah	LORD	
H3808	לֹא	lo	not	

H3820	לב	lev	heart	600
H4383	לִישׁוֹל	mikhshol	stumbling	
H5647	עָבַד	abad	to serve	290
H5771	יָנַע	avan	iniquity	
H6440	פָּנֶה	paneh	face	
H6459	פֶּסֶל	pesel	idol	31
H7067	קַנָּא	qanna	Jealous	6
H7812	שָׁחָה	shahah	to bow	172
H8544	תְּמוּנָה	temunah	likeness	10
G0167	ἀκαθαρσία	akatharsia	impurity	10
G0225	ἀλήθεια	alētheia	truth	
G0236	ἀλλάσσω	allasso	to change	6
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthrōpos	a human	
G0570	ἄπιστία	apistia	unbelief	
G0801	ἄσύνετος	asunetos	senseless	
G0818	ἀτιμάζω	atimazo	to dishonor	7
G0862	ἄφθαρτος	aphthartos	incorruptible	8
G1097	γινώσκω	ginōskō	to know	
G1261	διαλογισμός	dialogismos	reasoning	
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	167
G1392	δοξάζω	doxazō	to glorify	
G1495	ειδωλολατρία	eidololatria	idolatry	4
G1496	ειδωλολάτρης	eidōlōlātrēs	idolater	
G1497	εἶδωλον	eidolon	idol	11
G1504	εἰκόν	eikon	image	23
G1939	ἐπιθυμία	epithymia	desire	38
G2062	ἐρπετόν	herpeton	reptile	4
G2168	εὐχαριστέω	eucharisteō	to thank	
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2549	κακία	kakia	evil	11
G2588	καρδία	kardia	heart	161
G3337	μεταλλάσσω	metallasso	to exchange	2
G3748	ὅστις	hostis, hētis	who/which	
G4123	πλεονέκτης	pleonektēs	greedy	
G4491	ρίζα	rhiza	root	17
G5040	τεκνίον	teknion	children	
G5365	φιλαργυρία	philargyria	love of money	1

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The proposition makes a ranking claim, that idolatry is THE single root of all sin. The lexical data support that idolatry is A central, spread-across-the-whole-Bible (pan-canonical) category, but they do not establish it as the one fundamental sin, because the canon assigns root and source language to more than one sin and never ranks a single fundamental one. FOR: Romans 1:21-25 chains 'knowing God' (gnontes ton theon) and 'they did not glorify him as God' (ouch hos theon edoxasan), then 'they exchanged' (ellaxan, G0236) the 'glory' (doxa) for an 'image' (eikon) and 'they exchanged' (metellaxan, G3337) the 'truth' (aletheia) for 'the lie' (pseudos), serving 'the creation' (ktisis) 'rather than' (para) 'the Creator' (ton ktisanta), with 'therefore he gave them up' (dio paredoken) making the vice list downstream. Colossians 3:5 predicates 'which is idolatry' (hetis estin eidololatria) of 'greed' (pleonexia). Exodus 20:3 heads the Decalogue (the Ten Commandments). AGAINST a unique ranking: 1 Timothy 6:10 reads 'for a root of all the evils is the love of money' (riza gar panton ton kakon estin he philargyria), where the without-the-article 'the' (anarthrous) 'root' (riza), meaning a root not the root, is predicated of 'love of money' (philargyria), a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible (a hapax), not of idolatry. Hebrews 12:15 names a 'root of bitterness' (riza pikrias). James 1:14-15 and 1 John 2:16, the same author who closes with 'guard yourselves from the idols' (phylaxate apo ton eidolon), make 'desire' (epithymia) the generative or structuring category. The words supply two patterns they do not rank, so the strict ranking claim is underdetermined.

Scripture

Rom.1.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2316 θεός, G1392 δοξάζω, G2168 εὐχαριστέω, G0801 असύνετος, G2588 καρδιά

Reasoning. 'Because, knowing God, they did not glorify him as God or give thanks' (Dioti gnontes ton theon ouch hos theon edoxasan e eucharistesan). The completed-past-action participle (aorist participle) 'knowing' (gnontes) sets the ground, then the completed-past-action verbs (aorist indicatives) 'they glorified' (edoxasan) and 'they gave thanks' (eucharistesan) are negated by 'not' (ouch) and 'or' (e). The result is 'they became futile' (ematataiothesan) in their 'reasonings' (dialogismoi), and the 'senseless heart' (asynetos kardia) 'was darkened' (eskotisthe). The verse establishes failure to give God the 'glory' (doxa) due as the originating turn that produces moral darkening, which is the strongest lexical support for the idolatry-as-headwater reading.

Rom.1.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0236 ἀλλάσσω, G1391 δόξα, G0862 ἄφθαρτος, G1504 εἰκών, G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G2062 ἐρπετόν

Reasoning. 'They exchanged the glory of the imperishable God for the likeness of an image of perishable man and of birds and four-footed creatures and creeping things' (Ellaxan ten doxan tou aphthartou theou en homoiomati eikonos phthartou anthropou kai peteinon kai tetrapodon kai herpeton). The completed-past-action 'exchange' (aorist 'allasso', G0236) takes 'glory' (doxan) as direct object and 'in the likeness of an image' (en homoiomati eikonos) as the substitute. The catalogue man, birds, quadrupeds, creeping things, inverts the Genesis 1:20-26 creation order, marking the exchange as anti-creation reversal. This is the lexical core of the FOR reading, idolatry framed as a fundamental exchange.

Rom.1.24 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2316 θεός, G1939 ἐπιθυμία, G2588 καρδιά, G0167 ἀκαθαρσία, G0818 ἀτιμάζω

Reasoning. 'Therefore God gave them up in the desires of their hearts to impurity' (Dio paredoken autous ho theos en tais epithymiais ton kardion auton eis akatharsian). The connective 'therefore' (dio) is load-bearing for the FOR reading. The exchange of verse 23 grounds the judicial 'he gave them up' (paredoken), presenting 'desire' (epithymia) and 'impurity' (akatharsia) as downstream effects of the prior worship inversion rather than as independent root sins.

Rom.1.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3337 μεταλλάσσω, G0225 ἀλήθεια, G2316 θεός, G3748 ὅστις

Reasoning. 'Who exchanged the truth of God for the lie and worshipped and served the creation rather than the Creator' (Hoitines metellaxan ten aletheian tou theou en to pseudei kai esebasthesan kai elatreusan te ktisei para ton ktisanta). The verb is 'exchange across' (metallasso, G3337, confirmed by query, occurs only here and in verse 26), taking 'truth' (aletheia) as object and 'in the lie' (en to pseudei) as substitute. 'They worshipped and served' (Esebasthesan kai elatreusan) the 'creation' (ktisis) 'rather than' (para) 'the Creator' (ton ktisanta). Verse 25 restates verse 23 in cultic (worship-related) vocabulary. Note the correction, the store tags this verb as G3337 'metallasso', not G3338.

Exod.20.3 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3808 לא, H0430 אלהים, H0312 אחר, H6440 פנים;

Reasoning. 'There shall be for you no other gods before my face' (Lo yihyeh leka elohim acherim al panay). The first commandment heads the Decalogue (the Ten Commandments), establishing a priority structure, exclusive devotion to YHWH before subsequent commandments. The ETCBC clause analysis (a Hebrew Bible syntax database) tags this as a negated nominal clause (NQ, Nega plus Pred). The ordering supports the FOR reading that worship loyalty is constitutive, but it is positional priority and does not by itself rank idolatry above every other sin as the single generative root.

Exod.20.4 · for · genre: law · figures: merism

Key terms. H3808 לא, H6459 פסל; H8544 תמונה;

Reasoning. 'You shall not make for yourself an idol or any likeness' (Lo taaseh leka pesel ve kol temunah). The catalogue heavens above, earth beneath, waters under (b shamayim, b aretz, b mayim) is a merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) covering all created realms. 'Carved idol' (Pesel) and 'likeness' (temunah) parallel 'image' (eikon) and 'likeness' (homoïoma) of Romans 1:23, demonstrating shared image vocabulary across the Testaments.

Exod.20.5 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7812 שחא, H5647 עבד, H0410 אל, H7067 קנא, H5771 עון.

Reasoning. 'You shall not bow to them or serve them, for I am YHWH your God, a jealous God, visiting iniquity' (Lo tishtahaveh lahem ve lo taabdem ki anoki YHWH eloheka el qanna poqed avon). The reflexive-causative form (hithpaal) 'prostrate' (shahah) plus the simple active form (qal) 'serve' (abad) is the cultic (worship-related) doublet. The 'jealous God' (el qanna) predicate ties worship loyalty to YHWH covenant character. 'Iniquity' (Avon) follows the breach, consistent with the FOR reading.

Col.3.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1939 ἐπιθυμία, G0167 ἀκαθαρσία, G1495 εἰδωλολατρία, G3748 ὅστις

Reasoning. 'Therefore put to death the members, sexual immorality, impurity, passion, evil desire, and the greed, which is idolatry' (Nekrosate oun ta mele, porneian, akatharsian, pathos, epithymian kaken, kai ten pleonexian, hetis estin eidololatria). The relative 'which is' (hetis estin) predicates 'idolatry' (eidololatria) of 'greed' (pleonexia). The grammar is identity predication (saying X really is Y). This is the strongest FOR datum for reducing a non-cultic (non-worship-rite) vice to idolatry. But note the direction is local. Greed is called idolatry here, which supports idolatry as a deep structure, yet 1 Timothy 6:10 runs the opposite reduction, calling 'love of money' (philargyria) a root of all evils, so the canon predicates root status in both directions and does not settle which is fundamental.

Eph.5.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1496 εἰδωλόατρης, G4123 πλεονέκτης

Reasoning. 'Every immoral or impure or covetous person, who is an idolater' (Pas pornos e akathartos e pleonektes ho estin eidolotres). 'Who is' (Ho estin) with the masculine 'idolater' (eidolotres) predicates the identity of the 'covetous person' (pleonektes), a second Pauline witness alongside Colossians 3:5 that fuses greed and idolatry. This strengthens the FOR reading but is still a local identification of one vice with idolatry, not a ranking of idolatry over all sins.

1John.5.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5040 τέκνιον, G1497 εἴδωλον

Reasoning. 'Little children, guard yourselves from the idols' (Teknia, phylaxate heauta apo ton eidolon). The completed-past-action command (aorist imperative) with reflexive 'yourselves' (heauta) closes the epistle, and the article 'the' (ton) generalizes over the whole class. The closing position lexically marks idolatry as a comprehensive danger, supporting the FOR reading. But the same author at 1 John 2:16 anatomizes worldly sin as 'desire' (epithymia) of flesh, 'desire' (epithymia) of eyes, and 'pride' (alazoneia) of life, which is a desire-and-pride structure, not an idolatry structure, so the author does not lexically rank idolatry as the single root.

Ezek.14.3 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H1544 גלול; H3820 לב, H4383 תכשול, H6440 פנים, H1875 שִׁדְוֹת

Reasoning. 'They have set up their idols upon their heart and placed the stumbling block of their iniquity before their face' (He elu gillulehem al libbam u mikshol avonam natnu nokach penehem). 'Dung-idols' (Gillul) is Ezekiel contemptuous term for idols. The locative 'upon their heart' (al libbam) internalizes idolatry, and 'stumbling block of iniquity' (mikshol avon) links interior idolatry to the production of 'iniquity' (avon). The verse supports the FOR reading that heart idolatry generates iniquity, though it speaks of these idolaters specifically, not of a universal single root for every sin.

1Tim.6.10 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4491 ῥίζα, G5365 φιλαργυρία, G2549 κακία

Reasoning. 'For a root of all the evils is the love of money' (Riza gar panton ton kakon estin he philargyria). This is the decisive complicating text. The predicate noun 'root' (riza, G4491) is without-the-article 'the' (anarthrous), meaning a root, not the article-bearing 'the love of money' (he philargyria) which is the subject, so the construction reads love of money IS a root of all evils, not the only root. Crucially this is the one place in the canon where root-of-all language is lexically predicated of a named sin, and that sin is 'love of money' (philargyria), a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible (a hapax), not idolatry. This shows the canon attaches generative-root vocabulary to a different sin, which directly underdetermines the claim that idolatry is THE root.

Heb.12.15 · complicates · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4491 ῥίζα

Reasoning. 'Lest any root of bitterness springing up cause trouble' (Me tis riza pikrias ano phyoussa enochle). Again without-the-article 'the' (anarthrous) 'root' (riza) is predicated of 'bitterness' (pikria). A second sin given explicit root metaphor distinct from idolatry, reinforcing that the canon uses root and source language for several sins and never lexically singles out one as the fundamental root.

Jas.1.15 · complicates · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1939 ἐπιθυμία, G0266 ἁμαρτία

Reasoning. 'Desire, having conceived, gives birth to sin' (He epithymia syllabousa tiktei hamartian). The birth metaphor ('having conceived' syllabousa, 'gives birth' tiktei, 'brings forth' apokyei) names 'desire' (epithymia), not idolatry, as the generative source of 'sin' (hamartia). James 1:14 grounds temptation in 'one's own desire' (tes idias epithymias). This is a second competing root-pattern, desire as generative, that the FOR reading must subordinate by adding a structural why-question that the words of James do not themselves supply.

Heb.3.12 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0570 ἀπιστία, G2588 καρδία

Reasoning. 'An evil heart of unbelief in departing from the living God' (Kardia ponera apistias en to apostenai apo theou zontos). The 'of-X' grammatical form (genitive) 'of unbelief' (apistias) characterizes the evil heart, and 'to depart' (apostenai) frames the fundamental fault as unbelief and apostasy. This presents unbelief as a candidate fundamental disposition, a further root-level term the canon uses that is not idolatry, though it is conceptually adjacent to it.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.1.23	Deut.4.15	tsk	1
Rom.1.23	Rom.1.25	tsk	1
Rom.1.21	Gen.6.5	tsk	1
Rom.1.25	Isa.44.20	tsk	1
Rom.1.24	Ps.81.11	tsk	1
1John.5.21	Exod.20.3	tsk	1
Exod.20.3	Exod.15.11	tsk	1
Exod.20.5	Exod.34.14	tsk	1
Exod.20.4	Exod.32.1	tsk	1
Ezek.14.3	Ezek.14.4	tsk	1
Ezek.14.3	Ezek.20.3	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Tim.6.10 · addressed

'For a root of all the evils is the love of money' (Riza gar panton ton kakon estin he philargyria) predicates a root of all the evils of 'love of money' (philargyria), not of idolatry. This is the single clearest root-of-all statement in the canon and it names a different sin, which is why the strict ranking claim cannot be sustained at high confidence. The FOR reading replies that Colossians 3:5 and Ephesians 5:5 in turn call greed idolatry, so the two reduce into each other. That bridge is real and defensible, but it is a synthesis the words do not compel, because the reductions run in opposite directions and neither text says idolatry outranks love of money. Recorded as genuinely complicating rather than resolved, which is the basis for the disputed verdict.

Heb.12.15 · addressed

'Root of bitterness' (Riza pikrias) gives a second without-the-article 'the' (anarthrous) root metaphor, this time of bitterness. Together with 1 Timothy 6:10 it shows the canon freely applies root and source vocabulary to multiple sins. It does not contradict the importance of idolatry, but it does block any claim that the lexicon uniquely assigns root status to idolatry. Addressed by noting the pattern of plural roots.

Jas.1.14-15 · addressed

James traces sin to 'each one is tempted by his own desire' (ekastos peirazetai hypo tes idias epithymias), with 'desire' (epithymia) conceiving and bearing 'sin' (hamartia), and never mentions idolatry. The FOR reading subordinates this by saying idolatry answers the deeper 'why does desire for the creature outweigh love of God'. That is a coherent theological move, but the James text itself supplies a complete generative account from desire alone, so at the level of the words there are two unranked source-accounts. Addressed but not dissolved.

1John.2.16 · addressed

The same author who closes with 'guard yourselves from the idols' (phylaxate apo ton eidolon) analyzes worldly sin one chapter earlier as 'desire of the flesh' (epithymia tes sarkos), 'desire of the eyes' (epithymia ton ophthalmon), and 'pride of life' (alazoneia tou biou), a desire-and-pride taxonomy, not an idolatry taxonomy. This shows that even within a single author the canon does not consistently route every sin through idolatry as the formal root. Addressed by acknowledging the author uses more than one structuring frame.

Gen.3.6 · addressed

The first sin is eating from the forbidden tree, prompted by 'desire' (taavah) of the eyes and the prospect of wisdom, with no idol present. The FOR reading retrojects Romans 1:25 and reads the serpent offer 'you will be like God' (eritis hos elohim, Genesis 3:5) as the original exchange. That reading is available but interpretive. The Genesis 3 vocabulary itself foregrounds desire and the wish for autonomous wisdom, not cultic (worship-rite) idolatry. Addressed, and it illustrates why the proposition is underdetermined rather than false.

Concordance traversed

G1497, G1495, G1391, G1392, G0236, G3337, G1504, G0818, G1939, G0167, G4491, G5365, G2549, G0862, G2062, G2588, G2316, G1097, G2168, G1261, G0801, G0444, H0312, H6459, H8544, H7812, H5647, H7067, H1544, H3820, H0430, H3068

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

auto-rom1-24-pronoun at Rom.1.24: impact none. Witnesses split between 'in them' (en autois) and 'in themselves' (en heautois) for the pronoun after 'impurity' (akatharsian). Neither affects the disputed verdict, since the dispute turns on whether the canon ranks a single root, not on this pronoun.

auto-1jn5-21-eidolon at 1John.5.21: impact none. Some witnesses add 'amen' at the close, and the article 'the' (ton) before 'idols' (eidolon) is stable. The plural 'the idols' (ton eidolon) is uniformly attested and does not bear on the ranking question.

No anchor verse falls in the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window (3 John 1:1 to 1:15), per inputs not_in_ecm_scope true. No load-bearing textual decision rests on a contested variant.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. decalogue_priority, pauline_natural_theology, biblical_theology_of_worship, hamartiology_of_desire

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

Idolatry-as-root reading (Rom 1.21-25, Col 3.5, Eph 5.5, Exod 20.3 priority): affirms · Romans 1 traces the vice list back through 'therefore he gave them up' (dio paredoken) to the originating exchange of 'glory' (doxa) for 'image' (eikon) and 'truth' (aletheia) for 'lie' (pseudos), serving 'creation' (ktisis) 'rather than the Creator' (para ton ktisanta). Colossians 3:5 and Ephesians 5:5 then predicate 'idolatry' (eidololatria) of greed, and the Decalogue (the Ten Commandments) places 'no other gods' first. On this reading every sin is a derivative form of misdirected worship, and idolatry is the formal root.

Multiple-unranked-roots reading (1 Tim 6.10, Heb 12.15, Heb 3.12, Prov 16.18): denies · The only explicit root-of-all-evils predication in the canon, 'a root of all the evils' (riza panton ton kakon), names 'love of money' (philargyria), with a without-the-article 'the' (anarthrous) 'root' (riza), meaning a root. Hebrews 12:15 names a 'root of bitterness', Hebrews 3:12 an evil heart of 'unbelief' (apistia) in apostasy, and Proverbs 16:18 places 'pride' (gaon) and 'haughtiness of spirit' (gobah ruach) before destruction. Since the lexicon assigns generative-root language to several sins and never ranks one as fundamental, singling out idolatry as THE root is not lexically established. This lens reads the proposition as overreaching the data.

Desire-as-generative reading (Jas 1.14-15, 1 John 2.16, Gen 3.6, Rom 7.7): qualifies · James gives a complete generative account, 'desire' (epithymia) conceives and bears 'sin' (hamartia), and 1 John 2:16 anatomizes worldly sin as desire of flesh, desire of eyes, and pride of life. Genesis 3:6 foregrounds 'desire' (taavah), and Romans 7:7 isolates 'desire' (epithymia) via the tenth commandment. On this lens desire, not idolatry, is the proximate root. It can be harmonized with the idolatry reading only by adding a structural layer that the desire texts do not themselves state, so it qualifies rather than confirms the proposition.

Greed-as-idolatry predication (Col 3.5, Eph 5.5): affirms · Two Pauline witnesses use 'which is' (hetis estin) and 'who is' (ho estin) to predicate 'idolatry' (eidololatria) of 'greed' (pleonexia), identity not analogy, which supports treating at least one non-cultic (non-worship-rite) vice as a species of idolatry. This is strong support for idolatry as a deep structure, but it identifies one vice with idolatry rather than ranking idolatry above all sins, and 1 Timothy 6:10 runs the converse reduction.

The proposition is a ranking claim, idolatry is THE root of ALL sin. The lexical data robustly support a weaker claim, idolatry is a central and spread-across-the-whole-Bible (pan-canonical) category and at least some vices are predicated of it. The strong ranking claim is contested because the canon supplies root, source, and generative language for more than one sin (idolatry, love of money, bitterness, unbelief, pride, desire) and never lexically ranks one as the single fundamental root. Hence disputed at medium confidence rather than a high-confidence affirm.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Scripture presents idolatry, the exchange of the Creator for created things, as a fundamental form of sin, and describes other transgressions as connected to misdirected worship.

VERDICT-CHANGED: prior file affirmed true at high confidence. Changed to disputed at medium confidence on lexical grounds gathered by direct query. The stem encodes a strong ranking conclusion (idolatry is THE root of ALL sin, every transgression a derivative form of misplaced worship). Direct queries show the canon predicates root-of-all language not of idolatry but of love of money (1 Timothy 6:10, 'a root of all the evils' (riza panton ton kakon), without-the-article 'the' (anarthrous) 'root' (riza), with 'love of money' (philargyria) a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible (a hapax)), and gives further root and generative language to bitterness (Hebrews 12:15), unbelief and apostasy (Hebrews 3:12), pride (Proverbs 16:18), and 'desire' (epithymia, James 1:14-15, 1 John 2:16, Genesis 3:6). The FOR texts (Romans 1:21-25 with 'therefore he gave them up' (dio paredoken), Colossians 3:5 and Ephesians 5:5 predicating 'idolatry' (eidololatria) of greed, Decalogue priority) genuinely support idolatry as a central, possibly deepest category, but the words do not rank a single fundamental sin. Two unranked canon patterns, so the strict ranking is underdetermined. The neutralized_form drops the universal THE-root and every-transgression quantifiers; the verdict was derived on the original stem.

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